

Writing **Bad-News** Messages



Like all human resources professionals, Joan McCarthy, Senior Director of Human Resources Communication for Comcast Cable, sometimes has to deliver negative news to employees, whether it's about health care coverage, organizational change, or other issues. Her advice? "Balance, not spin, is the key. Frequent, candid communication that balances the good with the bad will go much further toward restoring and maintaining employee trust than the most creative 'spin.'"

Sometimes McCarthy will state negative news directly, while other times she takes a more gradual approach. Whichever pattern you use, "it's important to communicate openly and honestly," she advises. But you should also balance out the negative by "reinforcing the positive, putting the news in perspective, and showing what the organization is doing to help." In these ways you can

"communicate bad news in a way that preserves your company's credibility and keeps employee trust and morale intact."

This chapter contains additional strategies for minimizing the negative impact of bad news, whether you're delivering it to internal or external readers. ■

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- LO 6-1** Determine which situations require using the indirect order for the most effective response.
- LO 6-2** Write indirect-order messages following the general plan.
- LO 6-3** Use tact and courtesy in refusals of requests.
- LO 6-4** Compose tactful, yet clear, claim messages using an indirect approach.
- LO 6-5** Write adjustment refusals that minimize the negative and overcome bad impressions.
- LO 6-6** Write negative announcements that maintain goodwill.

LO 6-1 Determine which situations require using the indirect order for the most effective response.

APPROACHES TO WRITING BAD-NEWS MESSAGES

The indirect order is especially effective when you must say “no” or convey other disappointing news. Several research studies indicate that negative news is received more positively when an explanation precedes it.¹ An explanation can convince the reader that the writer’s position is correct or at least that the writer is taking a logical and reasonable position, even if the news is bad for the reader. In addition, an explanation cushions the shock of bad news. Not cushioning the shock makes the message unnecessarily harsh, and harshness destroys goodwill.

However, research also indicates that the direct approach is warranted for communicating negative news in some contexts.² In one study of “data breach notification letters” (letters a company uses to alert readers when the security of their personal

messages: indirect claims and adjustment refusals. Finally, we cover negative announcements, which are bad-news messages with unique characteristics.

LO 6-2 Write indirect-order messages following the general plan.

THE GENERAL INDIRECT PLAN

The following plan will be helpful for most negative-news situations.

Using a Strategic Buffer

Indirect messages presenting bad news often begin with a strategic buffer. By **buffer** we mean an opening that identifies the subject of the message but does not indicate that negative news is coming. That is, the buffer is relevant to the topic of the message but does not state what the rest of the message will say about it.

A buffer can be neutral or positive. A neutral buffer might simply acknowledge your receipt of the reader’s earlier message

You do need to use care when opening on a positive note. You do not in any way want to raise the reader’s hopes that you are about to deliver the news that he or she may be hoping for.

information has been compromised), the researcher concluded that when “writers must convince readers that a potential problem exists and encourage them to act,” a direct approach may be more appropriate.³

In addition, if you think that your negative news will be accepted routinely, you might choose directness. For example, in many buyer–seller relationships in business, both parties expect back orders and order errors to occur now and then. Thus, messages reporting this negative information would not really require indirectness. You also might choose directness if you know your reader well and feel that he or she will appreciate frankness. Although such instances are less common than those in which indirectness is the preferable strategy, you should always analyze your audience and business goals to choose the most appropriate organizational approach to delivering negative news.

As in the preceding chapter, we first describe a general plan. Then we adapt this plan to specific business situations—four in this case. First is the refusal of a request, a common task in business. Next we cover two related types of negative

and indicate your awareness of what it said. A positive buffer might thank the reader for bringing a situation to your attention or for being a valued customer or employee. You do need to use care when opening on a positive note. You do not in any way want to raise the reader’s hopes that you are about to deliver the news that he or she may be hoping for. That would only make your task of maintaining good relations more difficult.

Some may argue that not starting with the good news is, for savvy readers, a clear tip-off that bad news is coming. If this is the case, then why not just start with the bad news? The answer is that most readers appreciate a more gradual introduction to the message’s main negative point even when they know it is coming. A buffer gives them a chance to prepare for the news—and even if they suspect that it will be negative, the use of a buffer indicates consideration for their feelings.

Setting Up the Negative News

For each case, you will have thought through the facts involved and decided that you will have to say “no” or present some other kind of negative news. You then have to figure out how

you will present your reasons in such a way that your reader will accept the news as positively as possible. Your strategy might be to explain the fairness of a certain action. It might be to present facts that clearly make the decision necessary. Or you might cite the expert opinion of authorities whom both you and your reader respect. It might even be possible to show that your reasons for the negative decision will benefit the reader in the long run.

Whatever explanatory strategy you choose, these reasons should follow your buffer and precede the negative news itself. In other words, the paragraph after the buffer should start explaining the situation in such a way that by the time the negative news comes, the reader is prepared to receive it in the most favorable light possible.

Presenting the Bad News Positively

Next, you present the bad news. If you have developed your reasoning convincingly, this bad news should appear as a logical outcome. You should present it as positively as the situation will permit. In doing so, you must make certain that the negative message is clear—that your approach has not given the wrong impression.

One useful technique is to present your reasoning in first and third person, avoiding second person. To illustrate, in a message refusing a request for a refund for a returned product, you could write these negative words: “Since you have broken the seal, state law prohibits us from returning the product to stock.” Or you could write these words emphasizing first and third person: “State law prohibits us from returning to stock all products with broken seals.”

It is sometimes possible to take the sting out of negative news by linking it to a reader benefit. For example, if you preface a company policy with “in the interest of fairness” or “for the safety of our guests,” you are indicating that all of your patrons, including the reader, get an important benefit from your policy.



Setting up your bad news indirectly helps your reader receive the news more easily.

communication matters

You Think Saying “No” in the U.S. Is Tricky. . .

Maintaining goodwill with negative messages is often difficult with U.S. readers, even if one uses the indirect approach recommended in this chapter. But it can be even more difficult if you are corresponding with an Asian reader.

As intercultural business communication experts Linda Beamer and Iris Varner point out, “Asian cultures are renowned for saying yes. In fact, in Japan, Westerners have heard *yes* and gone home happy when the Japanese really meant *no*.”

Why does this happen? Beamer and Varner explain:

Saying *no* is more difficult for high-context cultures [cultures where communicators depend heavily on contextual cues to interpret words’ meanings]. As when they communicate about problems, they would rather not actually have to put a refusal into words. In Chinese, a *no* may reside in the words “That may be difficult.” The Japanese equivalent to that would be a drawn-out hissing breath and drawn-out words....

No in high-context cultures is frequently couched in an expression that turns the situation around. For example, a person who has to refuse an invitation to dine out with a business associate may say by way of refusal, “You must be very tired and want to have a quiet evening.” This way, the refused person does not lose face, although the refusal is clearly understood in a high-context culture.

Be careful to learn about such communication preferences on the part of your readers when preparing cross-cultural negative-news messages.

Source: *Intercultural Communication in the Global Workplace*, 5th ed. (McGraw-Hill/Irwin: New York, 2011) 194–195, print.

Your efforts to present this part of the message positively should employ the positive word emphasis described in Chapter 4. In using positive words, however, you must make certain your words truthfully and accurately convey your message. Your goal is to present the facts in a positive way, not to confuse or mislead.

Offering an Alternative Solution

For almost any negative-news situation that you can think of, there is something you can do to help the reader with his or her problem.

If someone seeks to hold an event on your company grounds and you must say “no,” you may be able to suggest other sites. If

someone wants information that you do not have, you might know of another way that he or she could get similar information. If you cannot volunteer your time and services, perhaps you know someone who might, or perhaps you could invite the reader to make the request again at a later, better time. If you have to announce a cutback on an employee benefit, you might be able to suggest ways that employees can supplement this benefit on their own. Taking the time to help the readers in this way is a sincere show of concern for their situation. For this reason, it is one of your most powerful strategies for maintaining goodwill.

Ending on a Positive Note

Since even a skillfully handled bad-news message can be disappointing to the reader, you should end the message on a forward-looking note. Your goal here is to shift the reader's



When you deliver an apology, make sure the apology is sincere.

If you do apologize in a bad-news message, do so early in the message as you explain the reasons and deliver the bad news.

thoughts to happier things—perhaps what you would say if you were in face-to-face conversation with the person. Your comments should fit the topic of your message, and they should not recall the negative message. They should make clear that you value your relationship with the reader and still regard it as a positive one.

Apologizing

Many times when a writer must deliver bad news, the first thought is to apologize. After all, if a customer or co-worker is unhappy—for any reason—somehow apologizing seems a good strategy for making a situation better.

Sometimes an apology can make a bad situation better, but other times it can make a bad situation worse. For example, if a customer incurs finance charges because you forgot to credit a payment to the customer's account, an apology, along with a credit to the account and removal of the finance charge, may help restore goodwill. On the other hand, if the bad news is something you had no control over (e.g., a customer didn't follow instructions for using a product and the item broke), apologizing can make you appear in the wrong even when you're not. A reader may also wonder why, if you're so sorry, you cannot do what the reader wants you to do. Apologies may even have legal implications if they can be construed as admissions of guilt.

If you do apologize in a bad-news message, do so early in the message as you explain the reasons and deliver the bad news.

Then move beyond the apology just as you move beyond the bad news and toward your forward-looking conclusion. If you think your apology may have legal implications, you can have your message reviewed by a supervisor or your company's legal department before sending it.

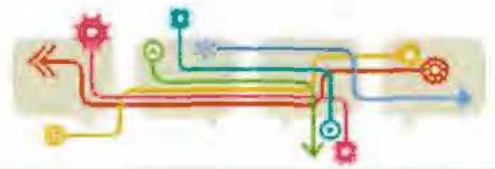
Following are adaptations of this general plan to four of the more common negative business message situations. From these applications you should be able to see how to adapt this general plan to almost any other situation requiring you to convey bad news.

LO 6-3 Use tact and courtesy in refusals of requests.

REFUSED REQUESTS

The **refusal of a request** is definitely bad news. Your reader has asked for something, and you must say no. Your primary goal, of course, is to present this bad news. You could do this easily with a direct refusal; however, opening with the bad news that you are refusing the reader's request could make you and your company appear insensitive. As a courteous and caring businessperson, you have the secondary goal of maintaining goodwill. To achieve this second goal, you must convince your reader that the refusal is fair and reasonable before you break the bad news.

workplace scenario



Denying a Request for a Donation

As in Chapter 5, assume the role of assistant to the White Label Industries (WLI) vice president. Today your boss assigned you the task of responding to a request from the local chapter of the National Association of Peace Officers. This worthy organization has asked WLI to contribute to a scholarship fund for certain children.

The request is persuasive. It points out that the scholarship fund is terribly short. As a result, the association is not able to take care of all the eligible children. Many of them

are the children of officers who were killed in the line of duty. You have been moved by the persuasion and would like to comply, but you cannot.

You cannot contribute now because WLI policy does not permit it. Even though you do not like the effects of the policy in this case, you think the policy is good. Each year WLI earmarks a fixed amount—all it can afford—for contributions. Then it donates this amount to the causes that a committee of its executives considers the most worthy.

Unfortunately, all the money earmarked for this year has already been given away. You will have to say no to the request, at least for now. You can offer to consider the association's cause next year.

Your response must report the bad news, though it can hold out hope for the future. Because you like the association and because you want it to like WLI, you will try to handle the situation delicately. The task will require your best strategy and your best writing skills.

Developing the Strategy

Finding a fair and reasonable explanation involves carefully thinking through the facts of the situation. First, consider why you are refusing. Then, assuming that your reasons are just, try to find the best way of explaining them to your reader. To do so, you might well place yourself in your reader's shoes. Try to imagine how the explanation will be received. What comes out of this thinking is the strategy you should use in your message.

One often-used explanation is that company policy forbids compliance. This explanation may work but only if the company policy is defensible and clearly explained. Often you must refuse simply because the facts of the case justify a refusal—that is, you are right and the reader is wrong. In such cases, your best course is to review the facts and to appeal to the reader's sense of fair play.

In any situation, you may have multiple ways to offer a fair and reasonable explanation. Your job is to analyze your audience and communication goals and select the one that best fits your case.

Setting Up the Explanation in the Opening

Having determined the explanation, you begin the message with a buffer that sets up the discussion. For example, in the case of WLI's refusal to donate to the National Association of Peace Officers' worthy cause (see the Workplace Scenario above), the following opening meets this case's requirements well:

Your organization is doing a commendable job of educating needy children. Like many other worthy efforts, it well deserves the support of our community.

In any situation, you may have multiple ways to offer a fair and reasonable explanation.

This beginning, on-subject comment clearly marks the message as a response to the inquiry. It implies neither a yes nor a no answer. The second statement sets up the explanation, which will point out that the company has already given its allotted donation money to other worthy organizations. This buffer puts the reader in an agreeable or open frame of mind—ready to accept the explanation that follows.

Presenting the Explanation Convincingly

As with the general plan, you next present your reasoning. To do this, you use your best persuasion techniques: positive wording, proper emphasis, sound logic, and convincing details.

Handling the Refusal Positively

Your handling of the refusal follows logically from your reasoning. If you have built the groundwork of explanation and fact convincingly, the refusal comes as a logical conclusion and as no surprise. If you have done your job well, your reader may even support the refusal. Even so, because the refusal is the most negative part of your message, you should not give it much emphasis. You should state it quickly, clearly, and positively; and you should keep it away from positions of emphasis, such as paragraph endings.

You might even be able to make the message clear without stating the negative news explicitly. For example, if you are refusing a community member's request to use your company's retreat facility for a fundraiser, you will convey "no" clearly if you say that you must restrict the use of the facility to employees only.



Telling people news they don't want to hear requires your most careful communication effort.

and then go on to offer alternative locations. You must be sure, though, that your message leaves no doubt about your answer. Being unclear the first time will leave you in the position of writing an even more difficult, more negative message later.

To state the refusal positively, you should carefully consider the effects of your words. Such harsh words as *refuse*, *will not*, and *cannot* stand out. So do such apologies as “I deeply regret to inform you . . .” and “I am sorry to say . . .” You can usually phrase your refusal in terms of a positive statement of policy. For example, instead of writing “your insurance does not cover damage to buildings not connected to the house,” write “your insurance covers damage to the house only.” Or instead of writing “We must refuse,” a wholesaler could deny a discount by writing “We can grant discounts only when . . .” In some cases, your job may be to educate the reader. Not only will this be your explanation for the refusal, but it will also build goodwill.

Offering an Alternative When Possible

If the situation justifies an alternative, you can use it in making the refusal positive. More specifically, by saying what you can do (the alternative), you can clearly imply what you cannot do. For example, if you write “What we can do is to (the

To state the refusal positively, you should carefully consider the effects of your words.



This refusal of a request email is harsh because of its directness and negative language.

Subject: Your request for a donation

Ms. Cangelosi:

We regret to inform you that we cannot grant your request for a donation to the association's scholarship fund.

So many requests for contributions are made of us that we have found it necessary to budget a definite amount each year for this purpose. Unfortunately, our budgeted funds for this year have been exhausted, so we simply cannot consider additional requests. We won't be able to consider your request until next year.

We deeply regret our inability to help you now and trust that you understand our position.

Mark Stephens

compromise), . . .” you clearly imply that you cannot do what the reader requested and avoid negative words.

Closing with Goodwill

Even a skillfully handled refusal is the most negative part of your message. Because the news is disappointing, it is likely to put your reader in an unhappy frame of mind. That frame of mind works against your goodwill goal. To leave your reader with a feeling of goodwill, you must shift his or her thoughts to more pleasant matters.

The best closing subject matter depends on the facts of the case, but it should be positive talk that fits the one situation. For example, if your refusal involves a counterproposal, you could say more about the counterproposal. Or you could make some friendly remark about the subject of the request as long as it does not remind the reader of the bad news. In fact, your closing subject matter could be almost any friendly remark that would be appropriate if you were handling the case face to face. The major requirement is that your ending words have a goodwill effect.

Ruled out are negative apologies, such as “Again, may I say that I regret that we must refuse.” Also ruled out are the equally timeworn appeals for understanding, such as “I sincerely hope that you understand why we must make this decision.” Such words sound selfish and emphasize the bad news.

Adapting the General Plan to Refused Requests

Adapting the general plan to refusals of requests, we arrive at the following outline:

- Begin with words that indicate a response to the request, are neutral about the answer, and set up the strategy.
- Present your justification or explanation, using positive language and you-viewpoint.

- Refuse clearly and positively.
- Include a counterproposal or compromise when appropriate.
- End with an adapted goodwill comment.

Contrasting Examples of a Refused Request

The advantage of the indirect order in refusal messages is illustrated by contrasting examples of WLI’s possible response to the request from the National Association of Peace Officers described in the Workplace Scenario on page 137. Both the example on page 138 and the example on this page refuse clearly. But only the one that uses the indirect order is likely to maintain the reader’s goodwill.

harshness in the direct refusal The first example states the bad news right away. This blunt treatment puts the reader in an unreceptive frame of mind. The result is that the reader is less likely to accept the explanation that follows. The explanation is clear, but note the unnecessary use of negative words (*exhausted*, *regret*, *cannot consider*). Note also how the closing words leave the reader with a strong reminder of the bad news.

tact and courtesy in an indirect refusal The second example skillfully handles the negative message. Its opening words are on subject and neutral. They set up the explanation that follows. The clear and logical explanation ties in with the opening. Using no negative words, the explanation leads smoothly to the refusal. Note that the refusal is also handled without negative words and yet is clear. The friendly close fits the one case.



This refusal of a request using the indirect approach builds goodwill.

Subject: Your Scholarship Fund Request

Ms. Cangelosi:

Your efforts to build the scholarship fund for the association’s needy children are commendable.

White Label Industries assists worthy causes whenever we can. That is why every January we budget in the upcoming year the maximum amount we believe we are able to contribute to such causes. Then we distribute that amount among the various deserving groups as far as it will go. Since our budgeted contributions for this year have already been made, we are placing your organization on our list for consideration next year.

We wish you success in your efforts to improve the lives of the children in our city.

Mark Stephens

communication matters

Delivering Bad News: A Sign of Leadership

Erika Andersen, author of *Leading So People Will Follow*, says that most leaders will likely identify delivering bad news as the hardest part of their job. At the same time, she says delivering bad news well demonstrates a leader's courage because "it shows that [he/she] will do things that are personally uncomfortable or difficult for the good of the enterprise." However, the act of delivering bad news is only courageous if the news is delivered effectively. Andersen offers the following suggestions for being courageous in bad-news situations:

1. Speak up: Hiding the bad news or ignoring it only makes a bad situation worse.
2. Be accurate: Andersen says leaders should be "simple, clear, true, and balanced." If

leaders minimize the importance of an issue or lose their objectivity, audiences cannot trust them.

3. Take responsibility: Leaders must acknowledge that as the face of the company, they are responsible both for what they do and for what the company does. Good leaders do not try to distance themselves from their actions or the consequences of them.
4. Listen: People naturally are going to be angry, frustrated, or afraid upon hearing bad news. Good leaders will let people work through their emotions rather than try to talk people out of them or make people feel as though their reactions are inappropriate.

5. Say what [they'll] do next: People expect that once leaders have taken responsibility, leaders will know how to make a bad situation better.
6. Do what [they] say—and repeat as needed: Leaders must follow through on their plans to remedy bad situations, which may mean addressing the concerns of several audiences individually or simultaneously. And leaders who do not follow through on their plans are viewed more negatively than if they never had any plans at all.

Source: Erika Andersen, "How Great Leaders Deliver Bad News," *Forbes*, *Forbes.com LLC*, 6 Mar. 2013, Web, 11 June 2013.

LO 6-4 Compose tactful, yet clear, claim messages using an indirect approach.

INDIRECT CLAIMS

When something goes wrong between a business and its customers, usually someone begins an effort to correct the situation. Typically, the offended party calls the matter to the attention of those responsible. This claim can be made in person, by phone, or by written message (email or letter).

Our concern here is how to make it in a written message. You would likely choose a written medium if you wanted a record of the interchange, were not on personal terms with the recipient, or knew that writing to the recipient would be quicker and more efficient than contacting the reader by phone. While some claim messages are written directly (see Chapter 5), many are also written indirectly when the writer anticipates resistance or a strong negative reaction on the part of the reader. In this chapter, we present an approach for writing **indirect claims**.

Choosing the Right Tone

Your goal in a claim message is to convince your recipient that you deserve some kind of compensation or remedy for a situation that has occurred. But even if you are completely in the right, you will not advance your cause with accusatory, one-sided language.

When writing this kind of message, project an image of yourself as a reasonable person. Just as importantly, project an image of the reader as a reasonable person. Give him or her a chance to show that, if presented with the facts, he or she will do the right thing. Do not blame or whine. Keep your tone as objective as you can while also making sure that the reader understands the problems caused by the situation. Focus as much as possible on facts, not feelings.

Leading into the Problem in the Beginning

A claim message needs to identify the transactions involved. This you can do early in the message as a part of the beginning. One way is to put the identification in the subject line of an email message or in the subject line of a letter, as in this example:

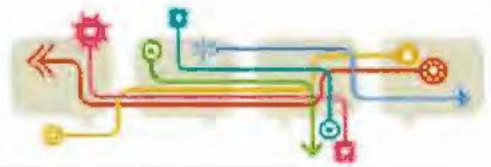
Subject: Fire Extinguishers: Your Invoice C13144

Another way is just to include a neutral but relevant buffer:

Today we received via FedEx Ground the fire extinguishers we ordered on 5 May 2009 (invoice # C13144).

Whether you use a subject line and your first paragraph or the first paragraph alone to introduce the problem, choose your words with care. Such negatively charged words as *complaint* or *disappointment* can put your readers on the defensive before you've even had a chance to make your case.

workplace scenario



Seeking an Adjustment for a Subpar Experience

Play the role of Jeff Sutton, owner and president of Sutton Creative Services. You've just received a bill from Regal Banquet Center for the winter-holiday party that your company held there last week. It's for \$1,410, which you had agreed to pay for an elegant three-course meal, plus drinks, for your 27 employees.

The food was as good as its reputation, but there were two problems. First, the room for the party was much too warm. You complained to the servers but to no avail. You would have

opened windows to correct the problem yourself, but the room you were given did not have any windows (something you weren't happy about either). Second, there was apparently a shortage of servers on the night of your event. Some of your employees had to wait a long time for their food, while those who had their food first either had to start eating before the others or let their food get cold while waiting for all to be served. This ragged timing ruined

the dinner, and it also threw off the timing of the program you had planned.

You were embarrassed by these problems. They reflected poorly on you and your efforts to thank your employees for their work. While you understand that unexpected problems can arise, you just don't think you should have to pay the full amount for a subpar experience. You'll need to write a claim message asking for an adjustment to your bill.

Describing the Problem Clearly

In the body of your message, explain what happened. The words describing the problem should be courteous yet firm. They should cover the problem completely, giving enough information to permit the reader to judge the matter. Present your case using facts and logic. If there were consequences to

what happened, include them. This beginning sentence illustrates the point:

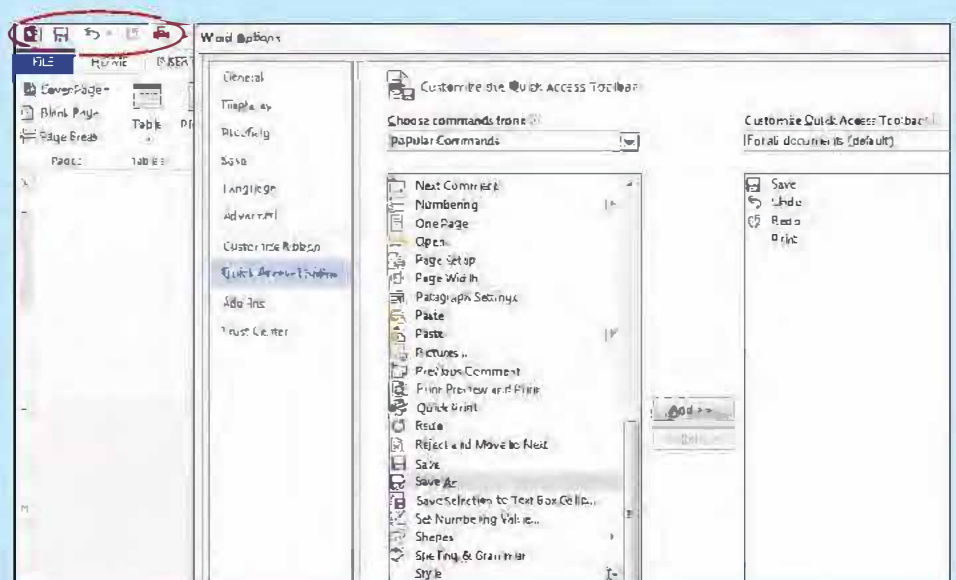
When we purchased a Quick Time microwave (Serial No. 713129), we were told that because of our light use and the quality of the microwave, we needed only the six-month warranty rather than the three-year extended warranty. We have had the microwave for only seven months, but it suddenly quit working.



from the tech desk

Customizing Your Word or Outlook Toolbar

As a writer, you repeatedly use some features in Word and Outlook (e.g., print, save, undo). Word and Outlook let you customize your toolbar (the space above the ribbon) so that you can more quickly access these options you use frequently. As shown here in Word, you can choose File > Options > Quick Access Toolbar. Once there, you simply click a command in the "Choose commands from" list and then click "Add." You can see that the items in the "Customize Quick Access Toolbar" list now appear in the Word document toolbar (circled). Whenever you need to use one of those commands, just select it from your toolbar.





Since unanticipated problems occur in business, writing a clear, complete, and fair-minded claim will usually solve them.



This blunt and accusing claim is unlikely to lead to a cooperative reply or further business with the reader.

Notice that this example uses the passive voice (“were told”) to avoid accusing or blaming language. You should follow these statements with any other evidence that supports your eventual request to replace the microwave.

Requesting the Correction

The facts you present should prove your claim, so your next step is to follow logically with making the claim. How you handle the claim, however, is a matter for you to decide. You have two choices: You can state what you want (money back, replacement), or you can leave the decision to the reader. You choose which, based on the situation.

Building Goodwill with a Fair-Minded Close

Your final friendly words should leave no doubt that you are trying to maintain a positive relationship. You could express appreciation for what you seek. However, you want to avoid the cliché “Thanking you in advance.” Instead, say something like “I would be grateful if you could get the new merchandise to me in time for my Friday sale.” Whatever final words you choose, they should clearly show that yours is a firm yet cordial and fair request.

Subject: Bill Adjustment

To Whom It May Concern:

I just received a bill for \$1,410 for the winter party that I held for my employees at the Regal Banquet Center. I absolutely refuse to pay this amount for the subpar job you did of hosting this event.

First, you put us in an unpleasant room with no windows even though we had made our reservations weeks in advance. The room was also much too warm. I asked your staff to adjust the temperature, but apparently they never did. Since the room didn't have any windows, we just had to sit there and swelter in our dress clothes. As if this weren't bad enough, it took the servers so long to bring all our food out that some people had finished eating before others were even served. This made a complete mess of the nice dinner and the scheduled program.

I had heard good things about your center but now regret that I chose it for this important company event. The uncomfortable and chaotic experience reflected poorly on me and on my appreciation for my employees. Enclosed is my payment for \$1,000, which I feel is more than fair.

Sincerely,
Jeff Sutton, Owner and President
Sutton Creative Services

Outlining the Indirect Claim Message

Summarizing the preceding points, we arrive at this outline for the indirect claim message:

- Identify the situation (invoice number, product information, etc.) and lead into the problem.
- Present enough facts to be convincing.
- Seek corrective action.
- End positively—friendly but firm.

Contrasting Examples of an Indirect Claim

The two messages on this page and page 142 show contrasting ways of handling Jeff Sutton's problem with the Regal Banquet Center. The first is blunt and harsh. The second is courteous, yet clear and firm.

a blunt and harsh message From the very beginning, the first message (on page 142) includes the writer's refusal

to pay and is insulting. "To whom it may concern" is impersonal, generic, and outdated. The opening paragraph is a further affront, blurring out the writer's stance in angry language. The middle of the message continues in this negative vein, accusing the reader with *you* and *your* and using emotional language. The negative writing continues into the close, leaving a bad final impression. Such wording is more likely to produce resistance than acceptance.

a firm yet courteous message The second message (below) follows the plan recommended. A subject line quickly identifies the situation. The first paragraph leads into the problem. Next, in a tone that shows firmness without anger, it tells what went wrong. Then it requests a specific remedy. The ending uses subtle persuasion by implying confidence in the reader. The words used here leave no doubt about the writer's interest in a continued relationship.

Subject: Invoice #3712 (for Sutton Party on December 12, 2014)

Dear Ms. Sanchez:

As you know, Sutton Creative Services held its winter-holiday party at Regal Banquet Center on December 12. While the food was exceptional, I have some concerns regarding our experience.

When I booked the party last August, I requested that we have the party in Salon A because of its size and view of the city. The room we were given for the event was Salon C. As you know, the room is small and has no windows. In addition, the location also had the drawback of making the temperature hard to control. The servers were sympathetic but were unable to keep the room from getting too warm for my 27 employees. I know that you book many parties during the holiday season; however, as the attached copy of our contract shows, we agreed that Sutton Creative Services would be in Salon A.

It also appeared that more servers were needed for our party. The fare was elegant, but with only two servers, some guests had finished eating before others had even started. As a result, we had to start the after-dinner program in the middle of the meal, requiring the speaker to talk while people were eating. This made it difficult for people to pay attention to his presentation.

Overall, the event was not the impressive "thank-you" to my hard-working employees I had in mind when we drew up the contract. In light of these circumstances, I am requesting a revised invoice of \$1,000. I believe this is a fair amount for an experience that I am sure did not represent the Regal's typical level of customer service.

I would be grateful for your response by the end of the month so that I can forward the adjusted bill to my accountant for payment.

Sincerely yours,
Jeff Sutton, President and Owner
Sutton Creative Services



This more tactful but honest claim invites the reader to do what is fair and retains goodwill.

Refused Request Message to an External Audience (Denying an Artist's Request)

A regional medical facility displays local artists' work at its various satellite locations. Artists submit applications to have their work displayed. This message shows a good strategy for denying a request to

an artist who applied to have her work displayed in the Lake Superior Family Medicine Clinic's reception area.

Lake Superior Family Medicine Clinic

Visit us: Web: <https://www.lsfm.org>

Lake Superior Family Medicine Clinic
4546 Burger Lane
North Concord, WI 54746
Web: www.lsfm.org
phone: 715-987-4958
fax: 715-567-7684

June 15, 2014

Ms. Jane Burroughs
2942 County Highway J
North Concord, WI 54746

Dear Ms. Burroughs:

Relevant,
neutral
buffer—
gains the
reader's
favor by
thanking her

Thank you for submitting your artwork for display at Lake Superior Family Medicine Clinic. The jury's deliberation process took more time than expected due to the number of submissions. Such a delay is a rare occurrence, so your patience was appreciated.

Provides a
reasonable,
convincing
explanation
supported
by a fact

The Medical Center's art wall and case is a free service open to local artists like you. This exhibit area has been embraced by not only artists but also community members because of the beauty it showcases. In fact, it's so popular that we had 75 requests from local artists last month. Due to the limited wall space available and the large number of art submissions, your artwork was not chosen for display at this time.

Offers an
alternative

The jury enjoyed your pieces and noted that your art "personified light." We encourage you to submit up to 10 pieces from your collection once again in 120 days. As outlined in the initial request letter dated May 22, 2014, artists can submit up to 10 submissions every 120 days.

Provides a
relevant,
forward-
looking
conclusion
that
builds
goodwill

If you have any questions, please contact me. Again, thank you for submitting your artwork. We look forward to your next submission.

Sincerely,

Samantha Kennedy

Director, Marketing/Community Relations
Lake Superior Family Medicine Clinic
Email: sakennedy@lsfmc.org
Phone: 715-456-7890

case illustration

Refused Request Message to an Internal Audience (Saying “No” to an Employee)

This message denies a hard-working employee. Showing appreciation for his work and citing the CEO's directive are likely to keep the reader's goodwill. In addition, the writer shows respect for the

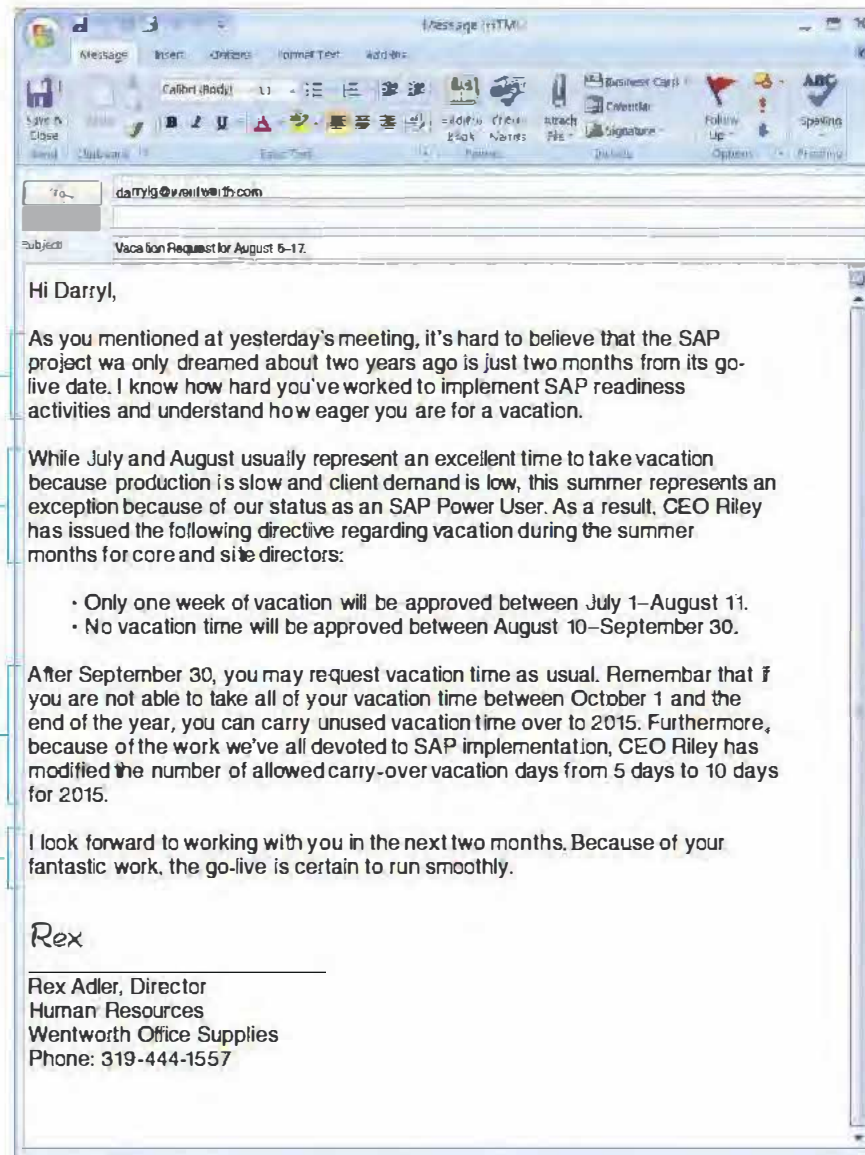
reader's request by remaining logical and objective in his explanation and offers a positive alternative.

Positive, relevant buffer highlights points the reader and writer can agree upon—presents the writer as a reasonable person

Logically explains the reasons for rejecting the reader's request

Provides good news and a positive alternative for the reader

Offers a goodwill close and moves beyond the bad news



workplace scenario



Denying a Customer's Claim

Sometimes your job at White Label Industries (WLI) involves handling a complaint. Today that is one of your tasks because the morning email has brought a strong claim for adjustment on an order for WLI's Do-Craft fabrics. The claim writer, Ms. Arlene Sanderson, explains that a Do-Craft fabric her upholstery company used on some outdoor furniture has faded badly in less than 10 months. She even

includes photographs of the fabric to prove her point. She contends that the product is defective, and she wants her money back—all \$2,517 of it.

Inspection of the photographs reveals that the fabric has been subjected to strong sunlight for long periods. Do-Craft fabrics are for indoor use only. Both the WLI brochures on the product and the catalog description

stress this point. In fact, you have difficulty understanding how Ms. Sanderson missed it when she ordered from the catalog. Anyway, as you see it, WLI is not responsible and should not refund the money. At the same time, it wants to keep Ms. Sanderson as a repeat customer. Now you must write the message that will do just that. The following discussion tells you how.

LO 6-5 Write adjustment refusals that minimize the negative and overcome bad impressions.

ADJUSTMENT REFUSALS

Adjustment refusals are a special type of refused request. Your reader has made a claim asking for a remedy. Usually you grant these claims. Most are legitimate, and you want to correct

any error for which you are responsible. But such is sometimes not the case as in Ms. Sanderson's situation above. The facts require that you say no. The following section shows you how to handle this type of message.

Determining the Strategy

The primary difference between this and other refusal messages is that in these situations, as we are defining them, your company will probably have clear, reasonable guidelines for what should and should not be regarded as legitimate requests for adjustment. You will, therefore, not have to spend much time figuring out



The adjustment refusal shows little concern for the reader's feelings.

Subject: Your May 3 claim for damages

Ms. Sanderson,

I regret to report that we must reject your request for money back on the faded Do-Craft fabric.

We must refuse because Do-Craft fabrics are not made for outside use. It is difficult for me to understand how you failed to notice this limitation. It was clearly stated in the catalog from which you ordered. It was even stamped on the back of every yard of fabric. Since we have been more than reasonable in trying to inform you, we cannot possibly be responsible.

We trust that you will understand our position. We regret very much having to deny your request.

Marilyn Cox, Customer Relations

why you cannot grant the reader's request. You will have good reasons to refuse. The challenge will be to do so while still making possible an ongoing, positive relationship with the reader.

Setting Up Your Reasoning

With your strategy in mind, you begin with words that set it up. Since this message is a response to one the reader has sent, you also acknowledge this message. You can do this by a date reference early in the message. Or you can do it with words that clearly show you are writing about the specific situation.

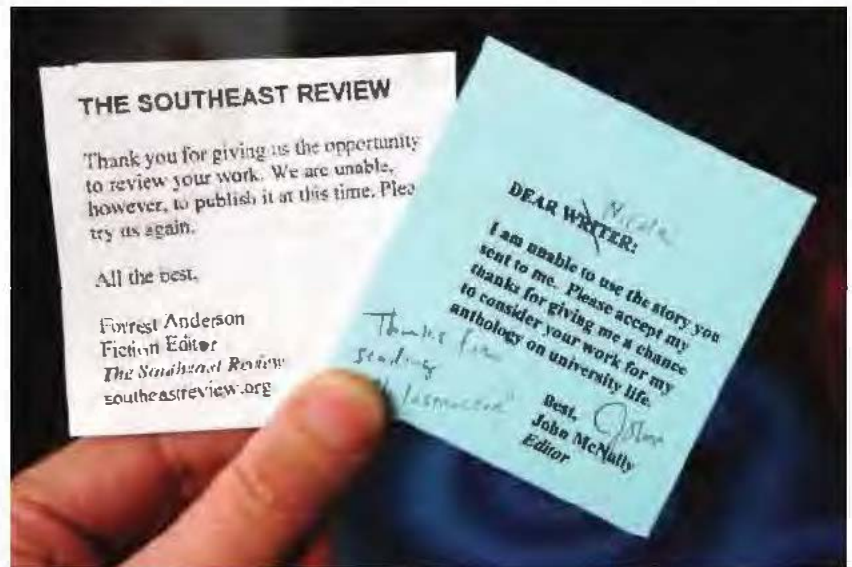
One good way of setting up your strategy is to begin on a **point of common agreement** and then to explain how the case at hand is an exception. To illustrate, a case involving a claim for adjustment for failure of an air conditioner to perform properly might begin this way:

You are correct in believing that an 18,000 BTU Whirlpool window unit should cool the ordinary three-room apartment.

The explanation that follows this sentence will show that the apartment in question is not an ordinary apartment.

Another strategy is to build the case that the claim for adjustment goes beyond what can reasonably be expected. A beginning such as this one sets it up:

Assisting families to enjoy beautifully decorated homes at budget prices is one of our most satisfying goals. We do all we reasonably can to reach it.



When refusing a request, remember how disappointing “no” can be and do all you reasonably can to spare your reader’s feelings.

The explanation that follows this sentence will show that the requested adjustment goes beyond what can be reasonably expected.

Making Your Case

In presenting your reasons for refusal, explain your company’s relevant policy or practice. Without accusing the reader, call attention to facts that bear on the case—for example, that the item



This adjustment refusal is indirect, tactful, and helpful.

Subject: Your May 3 Message about Do-Craft Fabric

Ms. Sanderson:

Certainly, you have a right to expect the best possible service from Do-Craft fabrics. Every Do-Craft product is the result of years of experimentation. And we manufacture each yard under the most careful controls. We are determined that our products will do for you what we say they will do.

We carefully inspected the photos of Do-Craft Fabric 103 that you sent us. It appears that each sample has been subjected to long periods in extreme sunlight. Because Do-Craft fabrics cannot withstand exposure to sunlight, our advertising, the catalog, and a stamped reminder on the back of every yard of the fabric advise customers that the fabric is meant for indoor use only.

As you can see from our catalog, the fabrics in the 200 series are recommended for outdoor use. You may also be interested in the new Duck Back cotton fabrics listed in our 500 series. These plastic-coated cotton fabrics are economical, and they resist sun and rain remarkably well.

If we can help you further in your selection, please contact us at service@wli.com.

Marilyn Cox, Consumer Relations

in question has been submerged in water, that the printed material warned against certain uses, or that the warranty has expired. Putting together the policy and the facts should lead logically to the conclusion that the adjustment cannot be granted.

Refusing Positively and Closing Courteously

As in other refusal messages, your refusal derives from your explanation. It is the logical result. You word it clearly, and you make it as positive as the circumstances permit. For example, this one is clear, and it contains no negative words:

For these reasons, we can pay only when our employees pack the goods.

If a compromise is in order, you might present it in positive language like this:

In view of these facts, we can repair the equipment at cost.

As in all bad-news messages, you should end this one with some appropriate, positive comment. You could reinforce the

illustrated by the messages on pages 146 and 147. The bad one, which is blunt and insulting, destroys goodwill. The good one, which uses the techniques described in the preceding paragraphs, stands a fair chance of keeping goodwill.

bluntness in a direct refusal The bad adjustment refusal on page 146 begins bluntly with a direct statement of the refusal. The language is negative (*regret, must reject, claim, refuse, damage, inconvenience*). The explanation is equally blunt. In addition, it is insulting (“It is difficult for me to understand how you failed . . .”). It uses little tact, little you-viewpoint. Because the close is negative, it recalls the bad news.

tact and indirect order in a courteous refusal The good adjustment refusal (page 147) begins with friendly talk on a point of agreement that also sets up the explanation. Without accusations, anger, or negative words, it reviews the facts of the case, which free the company from blame. The refusal is clear, even though it is implied rather than stated. It uses no negatives, and it does not receive undue emphasis. The close shifts to helpful suggestions

“ Putting together the policy and the facts should lead logically to the conclusion that the adjustment cannot be granted.”

message that you care about the reader’s business or the quality of your products. In cases where it would not seem selfish, you could write about new products or services that the reader might be interested in. Neither negative apologies nor words that recall the problem are appropriate here.

Adapting the General Plan

When we apply these special considerations to the general plan, we come up with the following outline for adjustment refusals:

- Begin with words that are on subject, are neutral about the decision, and set up your strategy.
- Present the strategy that explains or justifies, being factual and positive.
- Refuse clearly and positively, perhaps including a counter-proposal.
- End with positive, forward-looking, friendly words.

Contrasting Examples of an Adjustment Refusal

Bad and good treatment of WLI’s refusal to refund the money for the faded fabric (see the Workplace Scenario on page 146) are

that fit the one case—suggestions that may actually result in a future sale.

LO 6-6 Write negative announcements that maintain goodwill.

NEGATIVE ANNOUNCEMENTS

Occasionally, businesses must announce bad news to their customers or employees. For example, a company might need to announce that prices are going up, that a service or product line is being discontinued, or that a branch of the business is closing. Or a company might need to tell its employees that the company is in some kind of trouble, that people will need to be laid off, or, as in the Workplace Scenario (page 150), that employees will contribute more to the cost of their health insurance. Such **negative announcements** generally follow the instructions previously given in this chapter.

Determining the Strategy

When faced with the problem of making a negative announcement, your first step should be to determine your overall strategy. Will you use direct or indirect organization?

Adjustment Refusal Letter (Refusing a Refund)

An out-of-town customer bought an expensive dress from the writer and mailed it back three weeks later asking for a refund. The customer explained that the dress was not a good fit and that she did not

like it anymore. But perspiration stains on the dress proved that she had worn it. This letter skillfully presents the refusal.



103 BREAKER RD. HOUSTON, TX 77015 713-454-6778 Fax: 713-454-6771

On-subject opening

February 19, 2014

Ms. Cherie Ranney
117 Kyle Avenue E
College Station, TX 77840-2415

Dear Ms. Ranney:

We understand your concern about the elegant St. John's dress you returned February 15. As always, we are willing to do as much as we reasonably can to make things right.

Review of
the facts—
supports
the writer's
position

Negative
language
minimized in
the refusal

Friendly—
goodwill
close

What we can do in each instance is determined by the circumstances. With returned clothing, we generally give refunds. Of course, to meet our obligations to our customers for quality merchandise, all returned clothing must be unquestionably new. As you know, our customers expect only the best from us, and we insist that they get it. Thus, because the perspiration stains on your dress would prevent its resale, we must consider the sale final. We are returning the dress to you. With the proper alterations, it can be an elegant addition to your wardrobe.

Please visit us again when you are in the Houston area. It would be our pleasure to serve you.

Set-up for the
explanation

Good
restraint—no
accusations,
no anger

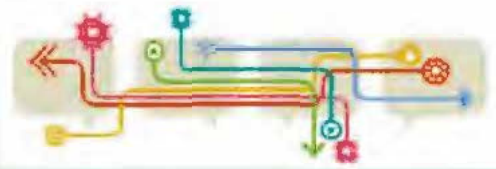
Emphasis on
what can be
done—helps
restore
goodwill

Sincerely,

Marie O. Mitchell
Marie O. Mitchell
President

dm

workplace scenario



Announcing an Increase in Health Insurance Costs

As the assistant to the human resources director at National Window Systems, you have been given the difficult assignment of writing a bad-news message for your boss. She has just returned from a meeting of the company's top executives in which the decision was made to deduct 25 percent of the

employees' medical insurance premiums from their paychecks. Until now, National Window Systems has paid it all. But declining profits are forcing the company to cut back on these benefits. Something has to give if National Window Systems is to remain competitive while also avoiding lay-offs.

The administrators decided on a number of cost-cutting measures including this reduction in the company's payment for medical insurance. The message you will write to National Window Systems employees is a negative announcement.

In most cases the indirect arrangement will be better. This route is especially recommended when it is reasonable to expect that the readers would be surprised, particularly disappointed, or even angered by a direct presentation. When planning an indirect announcement, you will need to think about what kind of buffer opening to use, what kind of explanation to give, how to word the news itself, and how to leave your readers feeling that you have considered their interests.

As in other negative situations, you should use positive words and avoid unnecessary negative connotations when presenting the news itself. Since this is an announcement, however, you must make certain that you cover all the factual details involved. People may not be expecting this news. They will therefore want to know the whys and whats of the situation. And if you want them to believe that you have done all you can to prevent the negative situation, you will need to provide evidence that this

When planning an indirect announcement, you will need to think about what kind of buffer opening to use, what kind of explanation to give, how to word the news itself, and how to leave your readers feeling that you have considered their interests.

Setting Up the Bad News

As with the preceding negative message types, you should plan your indirect beginning (buffer) carefully. You should think through the situation and select a strategy that will set up or begin the explanation that justifies the announcement. Perhaps you will begin by presenting justifying information. Or maybe you will start with complimentary or cordial talk focusing on the good relationship that you and your readers have developed. Choose the option that will most likely prepare your reader to accept the coming bad news.

Positively Presenting the Bad News

In most cases, the opening paragraph will enable you to continue with background reasons or explanations in the next paragraph, before you present the negative news. Such explaining will help you put the negative news in the middle of the paragraph rather than at the beginning where it would be emphasized.

is true. If there are actions the readers must take, these should be covered clearly as well. All questions that may come to the readers' minds should be anticipated and covered.

Focusing on Next Steps or Remaining Benefits

In many cases negative news will mean that things have changed. Customers may no longer be able to get a product that they have relied upon, or employees may have to find a way to pay for something that they have been getting for free. For this reason, a skillful handling of a negative announcement will often need to include an effort to help people solve the problem that your news just created for them. In situations where you have no further help to offer—for example, when announcing certain price increases—you can still help people feel better about your news by calling attention to the benefits that they will continue to enjoy. You can focus on the good things that have not changed and perhaps even look ahead to something positive or exciting on the horizon.



When making a negative announcement, remember that an indirect, tactful approach is usually better than a blunt or aggressive approach.

The ending words . . . can be whatever is appropriate for this one situation—a positive look forward, a sincere expression of gratitude, or an affirmation of your positive relationship with your readers.

Closing on a Positive or Encouraging Note

The ending words should cement your effort to cover the matter positively. They can be whatever is appropriate for this one situation—a positive look forward, a sincere expression of gratitude, or an affirmation of your positive relationship with your readers.

Reviewing the Plan

Applying the preceding instructions to the general plan, we arrive at this plan for negative announcements written in indirect order:

- Start with a buffer that begins or sets up justification for the bad news.
- Present the justification material.

- Give the bad news positively and clearly.
- Help solve the problem that the news may have created for the reader.
- End with appropriate goodwill talk.

Contrasting Examples of a Negative Announcement

Good and bad techniques in negative announcements are illustrated in the sample messages on pages 152 and 153 that announce WLI's plan to have employees contribute more to the cost of their health insurance (see the Workplace Scenario on page 150). The bad example is written in a direct pattern, which in some circumstances may be acceptable but clearly is not in this case. The good one follows the pattern just discussed.

directness here alarms the readers The bad example below clearly will upset the readers with its abrupt announcement in the beginning. The readers aren't prepared to receive the negative message. They probably don't understand the reasons behind the negative news. The explanation comes later, but the readers are not likely to be in a receptive mood when they see it. The message ends with a repetition of the bad news.

convincing explanation begins a courteous message The better example on page 153 follows the recommended indirect pattern. Its opening words begin the task of convincing the readers of the appropriateness of the action to be taken. After more convincing explanation, the announcement flows logically. Perhaps it will not be received positively

by all recipients, but it represents a reasonable position given the facts presented. After the announcement, comes an offer of assistance to help readers deal with their new situation. The last paragraph reminds readers of remaining benefits and reassures them that management understands their interests. It ends on an appreciative, goodwill note.

Using Directness in Some Cases

As we mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, in some cases it is likely that the reader will not have a strong negative reaction to the bad news. If, for example, the negative news is expected (as when the news media have already revealed it), its impact may be viewed as negligible. There is also a



Directness in this negative announcement sends an abrupt, upsetting message.

To our employees:

National Window Systems management sincerely regrets that effective February 1 you must begin contributing 25 percent of the cost of your medical insurance. As you know, in the past the company has paid the full amount.

This decision is primarily the result of the continued high cost of medical insurance and declining profits over the last several quarters. Given this tight financial picture, we needed to find ways to reduce expenses.

We trust that you will understand why we must ask for your help with cutting costs to the company.

Sincerely,

good case for directness when the company's announcement will contain a remedy or announce new benefits that are designed to offset the effects of the bad news. As in all announcements with some negative element, this part must be

worded as positively as possible. Also, the message should end on a goodwill note. The sample message below, announcing the end of a store's customer reward program, illustrates this situation.

Dear Ms. Cato:

Effective January 1 Frontier Designs is discontinuing our Preferred Customer program so that we may offer several new promotions.

Your accumulated points will be converted to a savings coupon worth as much as or more than your points total. Your new points total is on the coupon enclosed with this letter. You may apply this coupon in these ways:

- When shopping in our stores, present your coupon at the register.

- When shopping from our catalogs, give the coupon number to the telephone service agent, enclose your coupon with your mail order, or enter it with your online order at www.frontierdesigns.com/catalog.

In all these cases we will deduct your coupon value from your purchase total. If you have any questions, please call us at 1-800-343-4111.

We thank you very much for your loyalty. You'll soon hear about exciting new opportunities to shop and save with us.

Sincerely,

To All Employees:

Even though the Affordable Care Act has increased competition among insurance providers, the cost of medical coverage has not gone down for most companies.

Such is the case at our company. The premiums that we pay to cover our health benefits have increased by 34 percent over the last two years, and they now represent a huge percentage of our expenditures. Meanwhile, as you know, our sales have been lower than usual for the past several quarters.

For the short term, we must find a way to cut overall costs. Your management has considered many options and rejected such measures as cutting salaries and reducing personnel. Of the solutions that will be implemented, the only change that affects you directly concerns your medical insurance. On **March 1** we will begin deducting 25 percent of the cost of the premium.

Jim Taylor in the Personnel Office will soon be announcing an informational meeting about your insurance options. Switching to spousal coverage, choosing a less expensive plan with lighter deductibles, or setting up a flexible spending account may be right for you. You can also see Jim after the meeting to arrange a personal consultation. He is well versed in the many solutions available and can give you expert advice for your situation.

Our health care benefits are some of the best in our city and in our industry, and those who continue with the current plan will not see any change in their medical coverage or their co-pays. Your management regards a strong benefits program as critical to the company's success, and we will do all we can to maintain these benefits while keeping your company financially viable.

Sincerely,



This indirect bad-news announcement provides a well-reasoned explanation for the bad news.

Negative Announcement (Decreasing Work Hours)

Shop employees are told of the effects a slow economy will have on their work hours. The message is friendly and empathetic but clearly

conveys the negative news. The goodwill close looks forward to better economic times.

To: Zip Ready Manufacturing — Machine Shop Employees
From: Victor C. Baez
Subject: Summer Hours/Overtime/Vacation

Shop Personnel:

We have had a very good year so far: The performance of the department has been exceptional, and the feedback from our business unit customers has also been very positive. It's your careful attention to deadlines and quality that has helped us manage the fluctuations in our workload in the current economy.

As we all heard at our last quarterly meeting, the economy is still not growing at the pace we had hoped for. While our profits on sales have been above expectations, sales are behind our initial projections. Additionally, we will not be renewing the work orders for the six outside contractors until or unless the workload requires it. This being the case, we will need to temporarily adjust the shop hours. The current booked work should be enough to allow us to maintain a standard 40-hour week through the summer months; however, we will not be able to justify additional overtime. We are also asking that those with over four weeks' vacation take a minimum of two weeks between June 1 and August 31.

On the positive side, we fully believe that this is a short-term situation and expect to be back to full workload conditions by the end of FY2014 (September 30). Based on our sales and profits, we have also been able to set aside the scheduled first half of the employee bonus program.

As we move forward with these new schedules, I am confident in our ability to continue our excellent performance and eventually return to our normal schedules. If you have any questions, please contact your supervisor, Human Resources, or me.

Vic

Victor C. Baez
 Zip Ready Manufacturing
 Machine Shop Manager
 Phone: 904-567-2694
 Fax: 904-567-4598

A cordial buffer sets up the message

Reasons are objectively presented

Offers positive news related to the announcement

Offers a forward-looking conclusion



© Chris Ryan/age fotostock

master the art of breaking bad news!

- Do you want to learn more about tactfully breaking bad news?
- Would you like to learn how to apologize in a message?
- Would you like help in developing the appropriate tone for your bad-news messages?

Scan the QR code with your smartphone or use your Web browser to find out at www.mhhe.com/RentzM3e. Choose Chapter 6 > Bizcom Tools & Tips. While you're there, you can view a chapter summary, exercises, PPT slides, and more to learn techniques that will help you effectively deliver bad news.



www.mhhe.com/RentzM3e

active-review cards

Writing Bad-News Messages

The following questions will test your take-away knowledge from this chapter. How many can you answer?

LO 6-1 In what situations might it be better to use the indirect order for negative-news messages?

LO 6-2 What is the general plan for writing indirect-order messages?

LO 6-3 How would you adapt the general plan to refused requests?

LO 6-4 When is a claim written in an indirect pattern?

LO 6-5 How would you adapt the general plan to adjustment refusals?

LO 6-6 How would you adapt the general plan to negative announcements?

Practical Application

Consider the following message sent to a company's employees announcing a new policy in the workplace. Using what you know from Chapter 6 about how to write a negative announcement, what should the writer do to improve the message?

Beginning immediately, space heaters are banned from use in your individual office or cubicle. If you are using one, you must discontinue using it immediately or face disciplinary action.

Yes, I realize that some offices are colder than others, and many of you have space heaters, but unfortunately, whenever you use your space heater in your office, you affect our heating plant's ability to regulate the temperature evenly in the building. In other words, you make the matter worse, and the heating plant can't fix the problem of heating all areas evenly. If you have a problem with this new policy, we suggest you bring a sweater or dress in warm clothing.

We apologize for the inconvenience, but for the good of everyone, you must remove space heaters from your office immediately or face the consequences. If you have any questions, please contact me.

- If you determine that an indirect plan is best, you would start with a buffer introducing a topic related to the announcement.
 - You would next explain the situation that requires the negative news.
 - Your statement of the news would need to be thorough and clear, since people would not be expecting it and would be likely to have various questions about it.
 - You would then help people see what to do next or, if there were no next steps, focus on the positive side of the announcement (for example, that it helps solve a problem that the reader cares about).
 - Your close would help the reader feel as positive as possible about the situation and the writer/writer's company.
- LO 6-5**
- Your buffer would acknowledge the reader's request and indicate common ground between you and the reader (for example, that you both value quality or fairness).
 - You should explain the refusal using logical reasons and objective language. Your setup for the news could explain what your company's policy is in such cases and show—without blaming—that, under this policy, the reader's case does not warrant an adjustment.
 - You would say—perhaps as the statement of the refusal itself—what you *can* do to solve the reader's problem.
 - Your ending would be positive and forward looking, with no reminder of the refusal (such as an apology).
- LO 6-6**

- The indirect order is usually best when . . .
- You are delivering negative news and want to convince the reader that your position is correct, logical, and reasonable.
 - You are delivering negative news and want to cushion the shock.
- LO 6-2**
- Use a strategic buffer.
 - Set up the negative news.
 - Present the bad news as positively as possible.
 - Offer an alternative solution.
 - End on a positive note.
- LO 6-3**
- Your buffer would indicate that you are responding to a request but would not yet give your response.
 - Your setup for the news would be convincing reasons for having to say “no.”
 - The refusal itself, presented as positively as possible, would be short, leading quickly to what you *can* do or recommend.
 - You would end on a forward-looking note—not with a reminder of the refusal (such as an apology).
- LO 6-4**
- The indirect pattern is used to write a claim when the writer anticipates resistance or a hostile reaction from the audience.
 - Some of these hostile situations might involve large dollar or time requirements, unique occasions, tight practices, and more.

Did your answers include the following important points?

ANSWERS TO PRACTICAL APPLICATION

1. Begin with a buffer and then give reasons for the policy before announcing the bad news. 2. Omit the negative language. 3. Remove the threat of disciplinary action; just ask for compliance. 4. Focus on the reason that the plant is trying to fix the problem instead of on how employees are causing a problem. 5. Don't apologize or restate the bad news in the conclusion.